AN

ESSAY

ON THE

PRINCIPLE OF POPULATION,

AS IT AFFECTS

THE FUTURE IMPROVEMENT OF SOCIETY.

WITH REMARKS

ON THE SPECULATIONS OF MR. GODWIN,

M. CONDORCET,

AND OTHER WRITERS.

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PREFACE.

THE following Eſſay owes its origin to a converſation with a friend, on the ſubject of Mr. Godwin's eſſay on avarice and profuſion, in his Enquirer. The diſcuſsion ſtarted the general queſtion of the future improvement of ſociety, and the Author at firſt ſat down with an intention of merely ſtating his thoughts to his friend, upon paper, in a clearer manner than he thought he could do in converſation. But as the ſubject opened upon him, ſome ideas occurred, which he did not recollect to have met with before ; and as he conceived that every leaſt light, on a topic ſo generally intereſting, might be received with candour, he determined to put his thoughts in a form for publication.

The Eſſay might, undoubtedly, have been rendered much more complete by a collection of a greater number of facts in elucidation of the general argument. But a long and almoſt total interruption from very particular buſineſs, joined to a desire (perhaps imprudent) of not delaying the publication much beyond the time that he originally propoſed, prevented the Author from giving to the ſubject an undivided attention. He preſumes, however, that the facts which he has adduced will be found to form no inconsiderable evidence for the truth of his opinion reſpecting the future improvement of mankind. As the Author contemplates this opinion at preſent, little more appears to him to be neceſſary than a plain ſtatement, in addition to the moſt curſory view of ſociety, to eſtabliſh it.

It is an obvious truth, which has been taken notice of by many writers, that population muſt always be kept down to the level of the means of ſubſiſtence ; but no writer that the Author recollects has inquired particularly into the means by which this level is effected ? and it is a view of theſe means which forms, to his mind, the ſtrongeſt obſtacle in the way to any very great future improvement of ſociety. He hopes it will appear that, in the diſcuſsion of this intereſting ſubject, he is actuated ſolely by a love of truth, and not by any prejudices againſt any particular ſet of men, or of opinions. He profeſſes to have read ſome of the ſpeculations on the future improvement of ſociety in a temper very different from a wiſh to find them visionary, but he has not acquired that command over his underſtanding which would enable him